1. Digging to the Well

‘I’m sorry, lads. I can’t believe I just got out like that.’

Joe Root, waiting on the glass-fronted balcony of the dressing room at the Oval, smiled, slapped me lightly on the back and told me to ‘shut up’. He probably had a point, since the old ground hummed with excitement and commentators were suggesting I was some sort of national treasure, but batting is a serious business.

Joe followed me through a second doorway into an inner changing area, where I took twelve paces to my double peg close to the far right-hand corner. Life went on; the rhythm of professional sport is set by personal priorities, and Jos Buttler, surprised by the sudden fall of wickets, bustled in to complete his preparatory rituals.

After a brief flurry of congratulation, I was left to myself. I sat there for three or four minutes with my pads still on, savouring the silence and sifting through my senses. I looked around, through the organized chaos of discarded kit, lotions and potions. I was in a special, sacred place, where harsh truths are occasionally shared, yet balanced by the intimacy of individuals involved in something bigger than themselves.

The dressing room is a sanctuary, safe from the second guessing of social media and the exaggerated attention of the outside world. It is unique, precious. Each team is different, a collection of distinctive personalities, but this is the only place in which it can truly be itself. I loved that feeling of solidarity, freedom and friendship; that’s why, as captain, I encouraged players to linger over a beer at the end of play.